

VISUAL ANALYSIS WORKSHEET
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Close, careful looking (and a thoughtful response to what you observe) is the touchstone of all visual and material culture inquiry. It is an active process that forges the interface between the reality of the historical object and your own store of knowledge and experience. It requires a form of close, focused attention that is not part of everyday visual experience but that offers immense intellectual rewards.

Ideally, before beginning a research project about a work of art, you should plan to spend 3 hours with your object and to make *detailed* observations before doing any significant reading or research. Try to set aside any assumptions that you might bring to the object – approach it as if you were an alien visitor from another planet with no prior knowledge of the configuration or content of earthly art. If you have not been surprised by your object in some way, you haven't looked hard enough.

As you examine your object, consider each of the categories of description below. Remember that experiences like “I can't quite tell” and “yes and no” and “the work doesn't seem to emphasize that” and “that is absent from my experience” are also worth noting. Absences, suppressions, ambiguities, and opacities are also part of every work.

1) Measurement, proportion, and scale: what are the overall dimensions of the object (in both two- and three- dimensions)? Provide precise measurements if possible. What proportional relationships define the object, both in its overall form and among major internal elements? How would you describe the scale (or scales) of the work in its own internal relations, and relation to your own body and your surroundings?

2) Materials used: identify, if possible, all materials used. If you cannot identify them describe them as fully as you can. Note their patterns of distribution.

3) Fabrication: how have the various materials been assembled? Can you determine the processes used to fabricate the object? (For a painting, this would include questions of paint handling, layering, etc.).

4) Line: Identify and describe all linear elements, actual or implied, in the object. Are lines emphasized or deemphasized? What line weights are used? Is there an emphasis on smooth or rough lines, short or long lines, nervous or confident lines, choppy or sinuous lines (etc.)? Where are the prominent horizontal lines? Vertical lines? Diagonals? Are there implied lines that connect different parts of the object or different objects represented?

5) Geometries and formal echoes: Look for an emphasis or deemphasis on basic geometrical units like circles, triangles, cones, squares, etc. Look for patterns: repeating shapes, nesting shapes, symmetrical arrangements, etc. Identify relationships of scale and number among similar forms.

6) Organization of forms in 3D space: For an object: how are forms arranged in actual 3-D space? For a representation: how is 3D space implied, if at all? What about "negative space"?

7) Color: Identify (with as much precision as you are able) the different colors used. Then examine saturation and brightness. Examine patterning, distribution, and echoes much as you did with geometrical elements in step 5. Pay special attention to the way color interacts with the light around you, and with the texture in which it is embedded in the work.

8) Light: Where is the lightest light? The darkest dark? For representations: where is the implied light source, and how can you tell? Talk about range, contrast, sharpness or diffuseness.

9) Representational and textual content: Try to produce an inventory of everything (everything!) represented "in" the image or object. Note and transcribe any text. (For completely abstract objects, this step can be skipped).

10) Sensory impressions: what are your own (actual or imagined) sensory responses to the object beyond the visual? Consider hearing, smell, taste, and touch. If you are examining a representational image, note your responses to the image as object (i.e., a canvas with oil paint on it) and also project yourself "into" the depicted space and consider the sensory field implied by it.

11) Mobility and manipulability: How easy is it to move or manipulate your object (for representations: how easy would it be to move through the space? To move or handle the objects in it?) What leads you to these conclusions?

12) User profile or implied viewer: Based on your observations so far, speculate as to the status and characteristics of the implied ideal user or viewer. (How does the object *create* its ideal viewer or user?) What kind of person is assumed to be looking? An individual or a group? Where are they? What kind of a body do they have?

13) Temporal extension: think about the object's relationship to time. Does it imply or require a narrative or an action? Does it assume that something has already happened? Or that something will happen? Or does it attempt to evoke timelessness? If so, how well does it succeed, and why?

14) Viewing distance: How does the object change when viewed from different distances? Try to get "too close" (though not so much as to alarm the guards!) and "too far." Is there a distance that feels "right"? What are the effects you perceive from these different points?

15) Installation: How does the object relate to the works and objects around it and to the gallery space? Why do you think it is installed where it is?

16) Imagining Otherwise: Select a single element or quality of the object. Imagine it removed or altered. How would this change your impression of it? And is there something missing -- something that the work evokes but does not capture or contain in itself? Does it point to an absence? What is not there?

* For more on a structured approach to close looking, see Jules David Prown, "Mind in Matter: An Introduction to Material Culture Theory and Method," 1982.